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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY (BLUF)

Ukraine is stabilizing the frontline and conducting increasingly effective long-range strikes deep into Russia, imposing unsustainable attrition on Russian forces and causing internal Kremlin doubts about the war's trajectory. Simultaneously, Iran is using the ceasefire period to institutionalize de facto control over the Strait of Hormuz through a protection racket, while US-Iran negotiations remain deadlocked on nuclear enrichment and maritime transit issues. Russia's strategic nuclear exercises with Belarus underscore Moscow's deepening absorption of Belarus and its willingness to escalate nuclear signaling to offset conventional weaknesses.

KEY DEVELOPMENTS

- Ukraine's frontline stabilization and deep strikes into Russia (Moscow Oil Refinery, Angstrom plant) are imposing unsustainable attrition on Russian forces, with internal Kremlin doubts about the war's trajectory.
- Russia completed unannounced strategic nuclear exercises with Belarus, deploying nuclear weapons on Belarusian soil and planning 2027 'Union Shield' exercises with a potential nuclear component.
- Iran is institutionalizing de facto control over the Strait of Hormuz via a protection racket, while US-Iran negotiations remain deadlocked on HEU and maritime transit; Trump canceled a planned strike but maintains readiness for large-scale assault.
- Putin's visit to China failed to secure the Power of Siberia-2 pipeline deal, highlighting limits on Russo-Sino cooperation despite 40 minor bilateral agreements.
- Russia continues systematic coercion and integration of occupied Ukrainian territories, including child transfers, cultural integration funding, and economic absorption via banking and industrial restart.

UKRAINE CONFLICT: STABILIZATION AND STRATEGIC STRIKES

Ukraine's defensive operations are stabilizing the frontline, with NATO Secretary General Rutte and the DIA confirming Ukrainian territorial gains following Russia's loss of Starlink access in February

2026. Ukraine's intensified long-range strike campaign is imposing significant costs on Russian forces, with President Zelensky reporting over 59,000 seriously wounded and 800 POWs captured, and an average of 1,021 Russian casualties per day in 2026. Ukrainian strikes on May 16-17 hit critical Russian defense industrial targets, including the Angstrom Semiconductor Plant in Moscow, the Moscow Oil Refinery, and multiple oil pumping stations, disrupting logistics and weapons production. Russia retaliated with a massive 546-missile-and-drone strike on May 17-18, but Ukraine's new domestically produced guided glide bomb will likely expand its battlefield air interdiction capabilities. Bloomberg reports that some senior Kremlin officials view the war as a 'dead end,' though Putin remains committed to seizing Donetsk and Luhansk oblasts by end of 2026.

Sources:

- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 22, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 21, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 20, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 19, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 18, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 17, 2026
- Ukraine's Fortress Belt: The Key to Sustaining the Frontline

RUSSIA-BELARUS NUCLEAR INTEGRATION AND STRATEGIC POSTURING

Russia completed combined nuclear exercises with Belarus on May 21, involving over 64,000 personnel, 200 missile launchers, and launches of Yars ICBMs, Zircon hypersonic missiles, and Kinzhal missiles. These unannounced exercises, held earlier than the typical October Grom drills, highlight Russia's deepening de facto control over Belarus, including the deployment of nuclear weapons on Belarusian soil. Putin and Lukashenko plan to hold 'Union Shield' exercises in 2027, potentially with a nuclear component for the first time. Concurrently, Putin's May visit to China failed to secure the Power of Siberia-2 pipeline deal, demonstrating limits on Russo-Sino cooperation despite signing 40 minor bilateral agreements.

Sources:

- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 21, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 19, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 20, 2026

IRANIAN STRAIT OF HORMUZ CONTROL AND NUCLEAR NEGOTIATIONS

Iran is using the ceasefire to normalize its protection racket in the Strait of Hormuz, claiming 35 vessels transited on May 22 after obtaining Iranian 'permission' and 'security.' The IRGC Navy is framing this as a legitimate maritime security service, but it constitutes de facto control over international waters. US-Iran negotiations have made only 'slight progress,' with Iran's counterproposal failing to commit to suspending uranium enrichment or handing over its HEU stockpile. President Trump canceled a planned military strike on May 19 after Qatari, Emirati, and Saudi leaders requested a delay, but the US remains prepared for a 'full, large-scale assault.' Iran is also reconstituting its drone and missile programs during the ceasefire, while the US seized two Iranian-linked oil tankers (M/T Skywave and M/T Celestial Sea) in enforcement actions.

Sources:

- Iran Update Special Report, May 22, 2026
- Iran Update Special Report, May 21, 2026
- Iran Update Special Report, May 20, 2026
- Iran Update Special Report, May 19, 2026
- Iran Update Special Report, May 18, 2026

RUSSIAN OCCUPATION AND COERCIVE INTEGRATION OF UKRAINE

Russia continues systematic efforts to integrate occupied Ukrainian territories, including preparing to transfer a child from the Oleshky Boarding School to Russia for medical operations, potentially violating international humanitarian law. Over 80 residents from the boarding school have already been transferred or deported. The Russian Presidential Fund for Cultural Initiatives is spending billions of rubles on 'cultural integration,' while VTB Bank expands influence via savings accounts and occupation officials introduce automatic SNILS assignment for newborns. Russia is also planning to restart production at the Ilyich Steel and Iron Works Plant in Mariupol, signaling long-term economic integration.

Sources:

- Russian Occupation Update, May 21, 2026

OUTLOOK

Ukraine's defensive gains and deep-strike campaign will likely continue to erode Russian combat power, potentially forcing Moscow to escalate nuclear signaling or pursue a negotiated settlement. Iran's Strait of Hormuz normalization scheme, if unchecked, could become irreversible, while NATO considers escort operations starting July 2026. Russia's failure to secure the PS-2 pipeline from China may accelerate its economic isolation and reliance on Belarus for strategic depth.

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